

A Career in Open Source Development

Open Source offers a world of opportunity, even for non-coders. In this article we give you the basic know-how on what you can expect and how to get started with Open Source as a career.

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The most unique thing about Open Source programming is that it offers all kinds of opportunities even to those who are non-programmers. The entire framework of Open Source is such that just about anyone with creativity can give expression to his idea.

Even if you don't have programming knowledge, you might be able to do some really good work with popular Open Source programming languages like Python. What you ultimately create with Python depends more on your creativity and less on your programming skills. Many non-programmers tend to give Android App Inventor a try. With the App Inventor you can use the drag and drop method to create the app of your choice. And if the product is good enough, you might be able to find buyers at the Android market place.

Most of the opportunities however, are available at the enterprise level. According to data released by the popular international job site, Elance, up to 20 percent of its top 50 most sought after skills in IT, are comprised of Open source technologies.

An open world

Venkatesh Krishnan is an Open Source enthusiast. He became part of the Open

Source community while he was still in school, when he had become habituated to downloading all kinds of software from sites like SourceForge. While he was in College, doing his Btech, he came in contact with the Campus Ambassador Program, which is the initiative of Sun Microsystems. He picked up many new trends in Open Source development and also managed to improve his programming skills. Today he is employed in an international technology company at a senior level, but in his free time he continues to contribute in various Open Source projects.

"If you are good at Open Source development, companies are going to come out looking for you," says Venkatesh Krishnan. "Every major company in the world, including names like Oracle, Google, Microsoft and IBM have major Open Source projects going on all the time." There used to be a time when Open Source was synonymous with Linux and Java, but now it includes several middle-

ware and enterprise applications. Open Source skills that are most commonly in demand include content management systems such as WordPress, Joomla! and Drupal. All three are good examples of on going Open Source projects that have been built by teams of contributors from around the world.

"The basic frame work of the data management system can be created by using WordPress, Joomla! or Drupal, but for putting special features in the overall set up, companies still need to hire competent professionals," says Venkatesh. There is also demand for open source database systems such as MySQL, and mobile, e-commerce and web server technologies. A normal Google search on Open Source projects will give you thousands of leads. Many of these projects are the brainchild of programmers, like Venkatesh, who work in corporate offices during the day and contribute to Open Source projects in their free time. You could be a Java developer by day and Python or Apache expert by night.

How to begin?

"Open Source has now become so vast that there cannot be any clear-cut guidelines for anyone to build a career in this field," says Prashanth Bhatt, software professional based in Bangalore. "There is nothing that stops a programmer from working with both licensed software and with Open Source. The difference between the two seems to be narrowing down." By participating in Open Source projects, you will be able to acquire new skill

